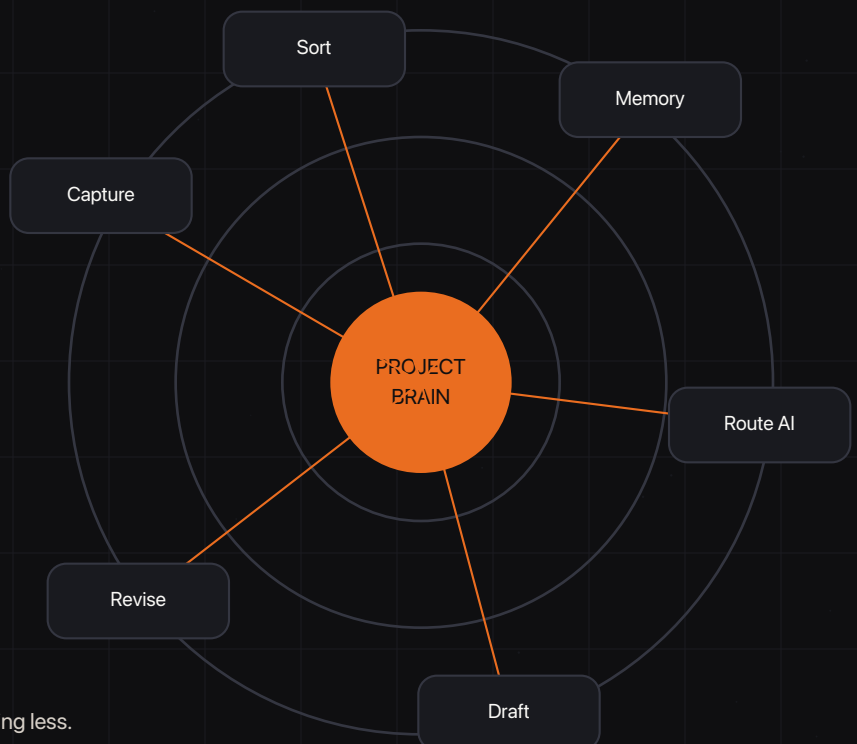


The Writer's AI-Age Flow for a Warm Manuscript

A complete guide to capturing, sorting, remembering, drafting, and
revising without restarting your book from zero.



The prolific writers are not generating more. They are losing less.

BuildOS / build-os.com

Start here: you are not blocked, you are cold-starting

Most writers do not sit down to a blank page. They sit down to a cold manuscript: a project whose characters, sources, decisions, and open threads cooled off while life happened.

THE OLD DIAGNOSIS

Writer's block

Try harder. Find motivation. Open another tool.
Generate ideas until something sticks.

THE BETTER DIAGNOSIS

Re-entry tax

The book is scattered, so every session begins with archaeology. The fix is manuscript memory, not shame.

USE THIS GUIDE LIKE A FIELD MANUAL

- Do not rebuild your whole writing life. Build one reliable Manuscript Home for one active project.
- Measure organization by one metric: can you resume in five minutes?
- Let AI help as a librarian, continuity clerk, and handoff assistant. The words stay yours.
- Keep this PDF open during setup, then print the quick reference and worksheets.

The 15-minute diagnostic: where your thinking leaks

Check every leak that costs you writing time. Your first system should solve the top two, not everything at once.



The notes graveyard

Useful fragments disappear into five apps and never resurface.



Research misses the page

The quote, passage, or source is somewhere, but finding it costs too much.



Losing the thread

A week away forces you to reread instead of write.



Continuity drift

Characters, timeline, locations, and rules quietly contradict themselves.



Feedback chaos

Editor, beta reader, and writing-group notes arrive in separate places.



The blank page

The page looks empty because the material around it is scattered.

WRITE YOUR TOP TWO LEAKS

1

Leak

What it costs you

2

Leak

What it costs you

Rule: solve the leak that blocks re-entry first. Momentum returns when the book can tell you where you were.

The full flow at a glance

This is the operating loop. Capture when thoughts are hot. Sort after they cool. Draft only after the material is staged.



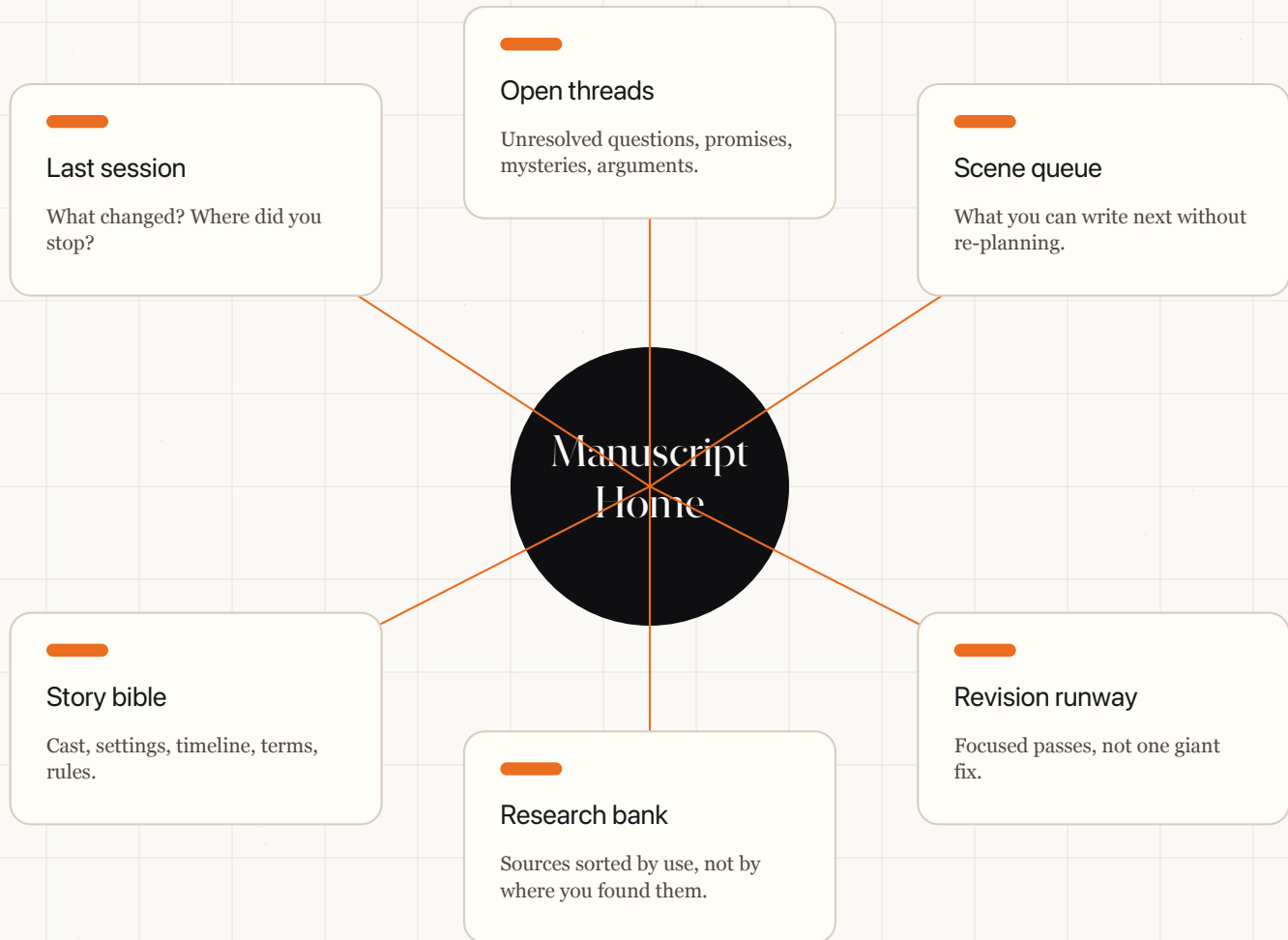
THE PRINCIPLE

Slow sort. Fast draft.

The prolific writer pays the sorting cost once so drafting can feel like assembly, not archaeology.

Build a Manuscript Home

A Manuscript Home is the place where the book remembers itself. It is not another folder. It is the current state of the work, kept warm between sessions.

**DEFINITION**

Organized does not mean color-coded. Organized means the next session starts with the book already loaded.

Step 1: capture frictionlessly into one place

Capture should be cheaper than forgetting. The inbox is allowed to be ugly. Its only job is to catch thoughts before they cool.

RULE

One inbox

Voice memo, phone note, paper card, or BuildOS brain dump. Pick one default landing zone for the active manuscript.

DO NOT

Sort while capturing

No tags. No folders. No naming ceremony. Capture first, decide later.

MINIMUM

Capture the edge

A phrase, a question, a contradiction, a line of dialogue, or the scene you realized has to exist.

CAPTURE PROMPTS

☐ Thing I might forget...

☐ Belongs near...

☐ Question to keep alive...

☐ Reader needs to understand...

☐ Do not lose this source...

THE CAPTURE STANDARD

If future-you can understand why the note mattered, it is enough. Capture does not have to be elegant.

Step 2: sort once, deliberately, and later

Do not process every note. Let the inbox cool. Survivors are the notes that still pull on you after time has passed.

THE SURVIVOR TEST

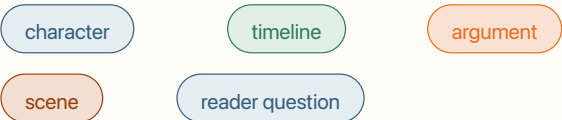
Keep it only if...

- It changes a scene, claim, character, or decision.
- It answers an open question.
- It creates useful tension with something already in the book.
- It is source evidence you can actually use.

THEME BEATS SOURCE

Move it by use

A source folder says where the note came from. A theme bucket says where it can help the draft.



SORT WORKSHEET

INBOX ITEM	USE	DESTINATION	NEXT ACTION

Step 3: keep one project brain

The project brain stores decisions, not just material. This is the difference between a pile of notes and a book that remembers what it has become.

01 Premise and promise

What this book is trying to give the reader.

02 Current draft state

Where the manuscript stands today.

03 Decisions made

Names, timeline choices, cuts, POV rules, argument rulings.

04 Open loops

Questions the book has not resolved yet.

05 Continuity ledger

Names, dates, places, character facts, rules.

06 Handoff packets

What an editor, beta reader, or AI tool needs to know.

WEEKLY PROJECT BRAIN REVIEW

Ask: What did the book learn this week? What decision should never have to be made again? What thread must be visible next time I sit down?

Step 4: route AI with curated context

Do not paste the whole project into a chat. Send the smallest useful packet for the job. Curated context beats raw context.

CONTEXT PACKET RECIPE

- 1 Job** What you want the tool to do.
- 2 Slice** The specific scene, chapter, source batch, or feedback group.
- 3 Memory** Relevant decisions, style rules, continuity facts, and open loops.
- 4 Guardrails** What it must not do, especially: do not write manuscript prose.
- 5 Output** The format you need back: checklist, questions, summary, pass plan.

USE AI AS

Librarian

Find the exact note, source, or decision that matters for this scene or claim.

USE AI AS

Continuity clerk

Scan for contradictions in timeline, names, rules, promises, and unresolved threads.

USE AI AS

Handoff assistant

Prepare packets for editors, beta readers, research passes, and revision planning.

Step 5: draft fast from staged material

Drafting is not the time to sort, research, or negotiate the book's identity. Drafting is assembly from material you already staged.

THE DRAFT SPRINT

45 minutes

Open one scene or section packet. Write forward. When a fact is missing, type TK. When a better idea arrives, capture it in the inbox, then return.

SCENE PACKET

- Purpose of scene / section
- What changed before it
- What must change inside it
- Material to use
- Continuity facts
- Exit hook / next beat

BUILD YOUR NEXT THREE PACKETS

	Scene / section	Staged material	Exit beat
1			
2			
3			

Step 6: revise with distance

Revision gets chaotic when every problem is handled at once. Build a runway of passes. Each pass has one job.



- 1 **Structure** Does the book move in the right order?

- 2 **Arc** Does the person, argument, or reader state change?

- 3 **Thread** Are promises opened, carried, and resolved?

- 4 **Continuity** Do facts, timeline, names, and rules hold?

- 5 **Scene** Does each scene earn its space?

- 6 **Line** Is the prose clear, alive, and yours?

- 7 **Proof** Final correctness after big changes stop.

Feedback is signal, not a verdict. Sort it by pass before you decide what becomes the book.

For fiction: keep the story world warm

World-building is useful only when it survives contact with the draft. Let your story bible accrete from scenes, closeouts, and continuity checks.

CAST

Character memory

Wants, fears, secrets, relationships, physical details, voice notes, and last changed state.

PLACE

Setting memory

Rooms, cities, kingdoms, rules, sensory anchors, travel constraints, and political forces.

TIME

Timeline memory

When events happen, what characters know then, and which promises are still open.

SCENE CLOSEOUT -> STORY BIBLE

After drafting a scene, add only what changed. This keeps the bible alive without turning it into a second book.

- ☐ New character fact
- ☐ New world rule
- ☐ Timeline change
- ☐ Relationship change
- ☐ Open promise / mystery

For nonfiction: keep the argument warm

The nonfiction version of continuity is claim discipline. Keep sources, claims, examples, and reader objections attached to the part of the draft where they matter.

01

Claim bank

Each claim needs evidence, a counterpoint, and a location in the draft.

02

Source ledger

Track source, useful passage, reliability, and where it supports the argument.

03

Example shelf

Stories, cases, metaphors, and analogies sorted by use.

04

Reader questions

The objections, confusions, and missing context your reader will bring.

RESEARCH-TO-DRAFT CHECK

☐ Changes the argument by...

☐ Belongs near paragraph...

☐ Supports or challenges claim...

☐ Answers reader objection...

Worksheet: the five-minute re-entry brief

Fill this before every writing session. If you cannot fill it, your Manuscript Home needs one more closeout, not another app.

WHERE I STOPPED

WHAT CHANGED LAST SESSION

THE NEXT SCENE / SECTION TO WRITE

RELEVANT MEMORY I NEED LOADED

OPEN QUESTION I SHOULD NOT SOLVE MID-DRAFT

MY EXACT NEXT MOVE

Worksheet: the session closeout

The closeout is how the story stays warm. Spend three minutes here before you stop, especially if the session went well.

I stopped at...

Leave tomorrow a door handle.

The most important thing I learned was...

Decision, insight, source, character fact, or scene problem.

Do not forget...

The fragile thought that will vanish overnight.

Next time, start by...

One concrete action, not a mood.

Add to project memory...

Continuity, source, open thread, or revision task.

Worksheet: sort feedback without drowning

Do not revise from raw comments. Aggregate the signal first, then decide the pass it belongs to.

FEEDBACK SIGNAL	PATTERN?	PASS	DECISION

Useful pattern test: if two readers are confused in the same neighborhood, believe the confusion. You still choose the fix.

Seven-day setup sprint

Use this if your current system is scattered. Do one small action each day. By day seven, your project has a home and a restart ritual.

DAY 1



Choose one active manuscript. Make the Manuscript Home.

DAY 2



Create the single inbox. Move nothing yet.

DAY 3



Process 20 old notes with the survivor test.

DAY 4



Write the current draft state and decisions made.

DAY 5



Build three scene or section packets.

DAY 6



Run one continuity or source-memory pass.

DAY 7



Write a closeout, then use the re-entry brief next session.

Prompt cards: AI that remembers, not writes

Copy these into the AI tool you use. Replace the bracketed parts with the smallest useful context packet.

LIBRARIAN

Using only this context packet, list the notes, sources, or decisions that matter for [scene/section]. Do not write prose. Return missing context as questions.

CONTINUITY CLERK

Scan this packet for contradictions in timeline, names, locations, promises, or world rules. Return a table: issue, evidence, risk, possible fix.

REVISION PLANNER

Sort this feedback into revision passes: structure, arc, thread, continuity, scene, line, proof. Do not rewrite. Give me the next three moves.

RE-ENTRY ASSISTANT

Turn this closeout into a five-minute re-entry brief. Include where I stopped, what changed, what to load, and the exact next move.

Printable quick reference

Keep this page near your desk. It is the whole system compressed.

1

1. Capture

One inbox. No sorting at capture time.

2

2. Sort

Let notes cool. Keep survivors. Organize by use.

3

3. Remember

Update Manuscript Home: state, decisions, open loops, continuity.

4

4. Route AI

Send a context packet, not the whole pile.

5

5. Draft

Write from staged packets. Type TK. Keep moving.

6

6. Revise

Run focused passes with distance.

ONE LINE TO REMEMBER

Be prolific by losing less.

The AI is not the bottleneck. The workflow is. Keep the story warm and the next sentence has somewhere to come from.



WHERE BUILDOS FITS

A project brain that keeps the book warm

This flow is what BuildOS is built around: talk through messy thinking, and the project becomes structured work with memory. For writers, that means a manuscript home, a re-entry brief, continuity reminders, and context your tools can use without making you paste your whole book into every chat.

BUILDOS HELPS

Capture

Brain dump rough project state, notes, scene problems, and decisions.

BUILDOS HELPS

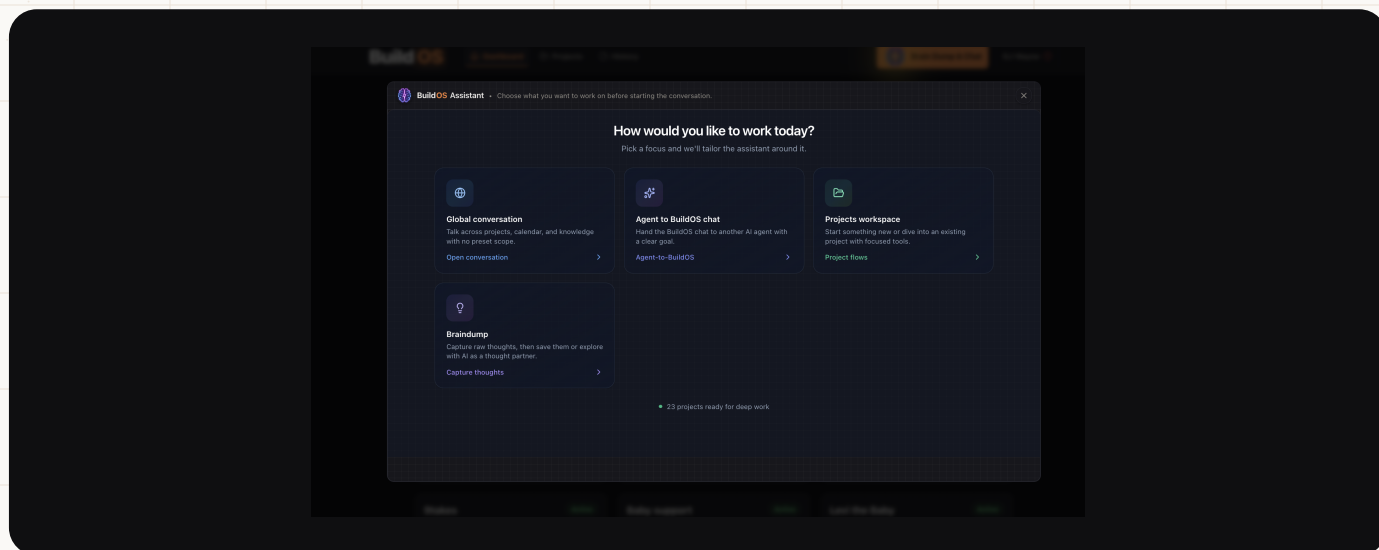
Remember

Keep project memory connected across tasks, docs, risks, and next moves.

BUILDOS HELPS

Resume

Return to the book with the thread already visible.



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